

An Appraisal of Struggle for Power in the Damaturu Area of Borno: A Case of Competition Between Kanuri and Fulani Groups Over Political Offices in the Pre-colonial Period up to 1960

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Abstract

This work is an appraisal of the struggle for Power between Kanuri and Fulani over political offices in the Pre-colonial colonial periods. The early contact of the two groups was traced to the 13th Century AD, during which time a socio-economic symbiotic relationship was the key component of their togetherness. The principal aim of the research was to explore the competition between the Kanuri and the Fulani over political power. Documenting the history of inter-group relationships can promote understanding and peaceful coexistence between the groups. It highlights their shared experiences, fostering a sense of unity and shared identity between them, building a stronger and harmonious community and perhaps informing policies that promote social cohesion. A qualitative approach using descriptive and analytical methods of research was adopted. The research therefore heavily relied on primary data that largely derived from oral tradition and archival sources, while library materials were also utilised. The work revealed that the group members are often friends, neighbours and partners who collaborate to develop many towns and villages. Wars were fought, rivalry developed and reconciliation and peace were reached. Consequently, Fulanis were co-opted into the mainstream of Kanuri political culture. Nevertheless, competition over political power continued to exist between them up to independence.

Keywords: Colonial; Competition; Power; Pre-colonial Struggle

Introduction

Historically, the Kanuri and Fulani are two groups that are originally sedentary farmers and nomadic pastoralists, respectively. The early contact of the two groups was traced to the 13th Century AD, during which time a socio-economic interdependent relationship was the key component of their togetherness. The Fulanis were honoured with the positions of Chieftains in various parts of Borno in the late 18th century; however, in the early 19th century, they rose against their host to snatch the leadership. This was the first outright challenge thrown by the Fulani to the leadership of Borno. Both groups derived their educational and socio-political civilisations from Islamic and Arab sources. However, the two groups were not equal partners right from the beginning. Thus, the early contact of either group with Arab-Islamic principles will justify the attainment of an earlier civilisation than the other. Based on this point, both groups tried to establish their legitimacy through theories that linked them to the Arab Heroes. Nonetheless, the degree of proof or evidence given by each group varies accordingly. Modern researchers sometimes relate cultural and linguistic similarities or even genetic information in cells like DNA, or proof of routes of transit and even proximity to the areas of the claims played a vital role in convincing one to

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accept the lineal connections. Hence, the two groups, being neighbours, friends and sometimes rivals, fell into competition and struggle for power since the Precolonial time up to the independence time. The research is on the political and Administrative Relationship between Kanuri and Fulani people of Damaturu Local Government Area of Yobe State. The research is specific to Damaturu and Kanuri and Fulani in particular because Damaturu was called 'Great Forest of Borno' in the 19th Century due to its pasture resources that attracted Fulani nomads from different directions. This made the area a great centre of Fulani influence in the 19th century. Moreover, the groups in question are the two major groups of the study area that have been together for many centuries in the area. The study covers the political situation of Borno at the eve of the Fulani rebellion of 1808, which in the long run resulted in general dissatisfaction of both groups. It studied the position of Damaturu in the 19th-century history of Borno and discovered the influence of the Fulani in the area. This work therefore examined the competition over political offices and struggle for influence and dominance of identity between the Kanuri and Fulani in Nigeria.

Political Relations between the two Groups in the Pre-colonial Period

The political relationship between the Kanuri and the Fulani people during pre-colonial times is traced to the 13th Century, when we were informed by Low that 'the first apparent reference to a Fulani presence in the Eastern region of Hausaland is found in chronicle allusion to the arrival c. 1250 of a pair of Islamic divines, Fulani of Melle (Mali) at the Court of the ruler of Kanem (then reigned at Njimi) near Lake Chad' (Sic)³ This is the first incident of contact between the two groups on record. There are four important issues related to the arrival of the Fulani to the Kanuri land. These are: their number, status, the venue where they met and how they were received by their host.

The author used the term 'pair of Islamic divine'. It is understood that the number of the Fulbe who appeared in the court of the Mai was two (scholars or jurists), since the term pair, by every interpretation, reflects two corresponding things with similar attributes. Thus, having seen two juries in the court of the Mai implies that there were numerous Fulbe in the land of Kanem among the common people, especially when we critically view the fact that the Fulani are originally nomadic and pastoralist in character. We may also assume that there were other Fulani scholars among the common people since only the opportune ones may get entry into the court of the Mai. Though their number in the court was nothing to write home about, their status as scholars or jurists had a direct bearing, linking them to the political system and glaringly showing their significance to the state. The warm reception by the host community and peaceful co-existence with the then Mai indicates their peace-loving attitudes.

It is on record that since the mid-sixteenth Century, Mai Idris Alauma of Borno had patronised and protected the Fulbe as Sa'ad posits;

His numerous campaigns against the Tuaregs and the Ngizim were to eliminate their threats to the Fulbe. So too did Alooma's attacks on the Gamargu, the scattering of the So peoples and the defeat of Mandara encourage freer mobility of pastoral Fulbe within the Borno Empire. Similar westward expansion of Borno under the Galadimas based at Nguru since

³ Victor N. Low, *Three Nigerian Emirates, A Study in Oral History*, USA (Evanston Illinois): Northwestern University Press, 1972, pp 66-69

the 17th Century was also of considerable significance since it brought a large number of Fulbe under the authority of the Mai.⁴

From the above quotation, it is clear that Mai Idriss Alooma fought his vassal states and neighbours from different directions to ensure liberty of aliens (the Fulani); thus, we may view that the pastoral Fulbe of those days were absolutely loyal and economically useful to the state; this may perhaps be the reason for Alooma's preferring ground for Fulani to settle in Borno. Authors ranging from Ibn Furtua/Palmer, Barth, Lavers and Stenning have narrated the incident of Alooma's wars with Tuaregs, Ngizim, Mandara, Gamargu or the entire So race in preference to pastoral Fulani of Borno. None of them has clearly given a reason as to why Alauma preferred Fulani to these groups mentioned. However, a skeletal reason is given by each of them, often saying the groups were posing threats or raiding the Fulani pastoral groups. An English proverb says 'give and take is a natural law'. In line with the proverb, we may ask this question: since the Mai had given them liberty, protection and security, what benefit did the Mai get from them? The simple answer to this question is that the Kanuri and the Fulani at that time were not in any form of competition; they produced different items needed by each other, thus enjoying symbiotic relations. We are also made to understand from the political relationship between the Fulani and the entire Borno at that time was cordial and harmonious that the Fulani, being settlers in the area, submitted themselves solemnly to the authority of the Mai, whereas the groups mentioned earlier were recalcitrant. It is logical that in any given state, the loyal and supportive citizens are given preference and even rewarded. In essence, the Fulani and the Kanuri relationships in most parts of the 16th Century might be generally described as peaceful and harmonious.

However, in the 18th Century, the story was never the same. By that time, the Fulani might have firmly established themselves economically and educationally. They might also, by that time, have learned everything about Borno, viz.: the strengths and weaknesses of the state, all the nooks and crannies of Borno alongside their neighbours and people bordering the state. On the other hand, the political system of the state was in a state of deterioration. Thus, justice and fair play were no longer seen in the system. For instance, Lavers disclosed that:

By the late 18th Century, the best grazing areas of Borno were occupied by Fulani. There is certain tension between the court and the Fulani scholars. This is the very time that Kanembu and Shuwa groups, themselves pastoralists, began moving in. The Kanembu, as a result of conditions in Kanem, moved North of the Lake and began settling along its Western shores. The Shuwa, many fleeing from Muhammad Al-Amin of Baghirmi, graze their cattle on the South-western shores of Lake Chad. Both groups were well received and were probably favoured over the Fulani.⁵

It is apparent from the above that Kanembu and Shuwa arrived later than Fulani and by the time of their arrival, the best grazing lands were already occupied by the Fulani. The two aliens were favoured over the indigenous Fulani pastoralists. We may vividly recall how Sa'ad described the character of the Fulbe: 'Their main concern in any area was to obtain a guarantee (*verdujye*) of their right (*hakke*) from the local authorities. The greatest need of Fulbe was land for grazing and

⁴ Sa'ad, Abubakar, *Lamibe Fombina, A History of Adamawa Emirate 1809-2008*, Ibadan: Book wright Nigeria publishers, 2008, p 53.

⁵ J. E. Lavers, 'Kanem and Borno to 1808', in Obaro Ikemi, ed, *Groundwork of Nigerian History*, Ibadan, Heinemann Educational Books Plc, 1983, pp 207-208.

to acquire this they tended to ally themselves with rulers, communities or clans'.⁶ Having appreciated the character of Fulbe for non-compromise of their rights, especially of land for grazing, there was open injustice shown to them by receiving and favouring the Kanembu and Shuwa. For Kanembu, it is accepted that they were part and parcel of the Kanuri, and ever since they were together with the Kanuri, no conflict has ever occurred between Kanuri and Kanembu, as recorded in history based on our little knowledge of the history of Kanem and Borno. It was also recorded that they were traditionally cattle breeders like the Fulani. But for the Shuwa, they were originally camel rearers, not cattle, but later changed to cattle rearing. This gradual metamorphosis gave them a new name called *Baqara* Arabs even among themselves. If not in the Chad basin area, there was nowhere in the world where the Arabs were known for cattle rearing. It is, therefore, likely that the Arabs learned cattle rearing from either Koyam, Bodowi, Kanembu or Fulani, or from any other group within the shores of Lake Chad.⁷ Though there was no open conflict between the Shuwa and the Kanuri, there were cases of helping the enemies of the Kanuri on many occasions. In all cases, the injustice shown to the Fulani has never been taken for granted, especially by the scholars among them, as Lavers explicitly said: 'There was certain tension between the court and the scholars'.⁸

Though the Fulani, according to Sa'ad, will ally with any group, clan or authority in pursuance of their interest, that is true, but they proved adamant in integrating into the social and political life of one another. For instance, though the Shuwa came far later than them, they successfully integrated into the mainstream of the political system of Borno, whereas the Fulani refused to integrate. This may not be unconnected to their trans-human and nomadic culture. Borno as a political entity was inclusive in nature. For instance, this could clearly be seen from the emergence of many Mais that have different ethnic linkages to groups such as Bulala, Afono, Shuwa, Wadai, Mandara and so forth.⁹ The Fulani could have taken advantage, since during the Mai Idris Aloma and integrated into the political system, but the feeling of exclusiveness on their side is too high, as lamented by Garba.¹⁰

Furthermore, it was in the second half of the 18th Century that the disagreements between Mai Ali Ajimi (1753-93) and Shehu Feroma occurred. Sa'ad described the event as: the Mai and the said scholar were friends, yet this did not stop the Mai from pushing him out of his court since his teachings and other activities were regarded by the Mai as subversive. This made the Felata scholar become frustrated, as most of the privileges he was usually enjoying from the state were revoked. The scholar was said to have coined a poem with some insulting words to the entire Kanuri race. For instance, he was the first to interpret the word Kanuri to mean 'Kanori'. This means the entire land of Borno was formerly owned by Kano. Thus, when the Sayfawa were driven out of Kanem by Bulala, they came and settled in a place owned by Kano; thereby, people who settled in the place are called Kano-ri. *Ri* implies place in *the* Kanuri language, as many places in Kanuri villages and Towns bear the suffix 'ri' in Borno, like Malari, Shuwari and Ngomari. This poem, according

⁶ Sa'ad Abubakar, *Lamibe Fombina*, pp 73-74.

⁷ Dr. Ibrahim G. (Age: 68, Professor of History, Department of History University of Maiduguri, telephone conversation on 29th September, 2023).

⁸ J. E. Lavers, 'Kanem and Borno to 1808', in *Groundwork of Nigerian History*, pp 207-208.

⁹ Dr Garba Ibrahim, (Age: 68, telephone conversation on 29th November, 2022).

¹⁰ Dr Garba Ibrahim, (Age:68, telephone conversation on 29th November, 2022).

to Abdulhamid, was formed by Sheikh Tahir Feroma just to offend the then Mai and the entire Kanuri people at that time.¹¹ At this point, the relationship between the two groups started to become sour.

The last decade of the 18th Century also proved a bitter relationship between the groups concerned. Thus, on the Southern border of Borno, it was said that Borno suffered a humiliating defeat in 1791 at the hands of Mandara. This also occurred in the first decade of the century at the hands of resident Felata of Daya District near Gujba. These incidents were beyond mere disagreements but were physical confrontations that involved violence between Borno authorities and the said communities. On both occasions, Mandara and Daya were assisted by Felata Borno to defeat the Borno forces. These situations, especially in the Daya district, led the then Mai Ahmad to pass a decree on the killings of Fulani in Borno land. Thus, many groups of Fulani deserted Borno lands.¹² Consequently, the first decade of the 19th Century was a period which historians termed the time of Felata uprising in Borno. This subject has been discussed by many authors; thus, it is not worthy of repetition to stress it. Under the prevailing situation at the time of the uprising, we can conveniently say that the relationships between the two groups were hostile. When the resident Felata in the Southern and Western Borno willingly joined the wars by launching their own in Borno, Fulata Mare, however, under Ardo Sa'ali, who were established in Borno probably since the 15th Century, had refused to enter the so-called 'Holy' war. But his son Wa'abi fell foul of El-Kanemi over a land dispute and, against his father's advice, fled to Shehu, from whom he obtained a flag. He returned to the Gujba area and launched attacks on the Kerekere and Ngizim. In 1820, Wa'abi and Manga joined forces, but their association did not last.¹³ Mare, like Ngara'en, were bilingual and mostly adopted the Kanuri tribal marks; therefore, they refused to join their kinsmen in the so-called 'Holy' war. The overall relationship between the Kanuri and the Fulani in the 19th Century was a hostile one, but there were pockets of cooperation and alliances between them.

Finally, the last decade of the 19th Century was a period of Rabi's invasion of Borno and his subsequent seven (7) year rule. During this period, the two groups were neither friends nor enemies, as both groups were victims of the same circumstance. For instance, the Kanuri had completely lost their political independence to Rabi, while the entire Fulani emirates of the Western marches of Borno, such as Katagum, Hadeja Misau and even the newly emerging state of Burmi under Malam Jibrila, were under serious threat from Rabi. Malam Jibrila was a Tijjaniyya Malam who began preaching in Katagum and acquired a considerable influence in the Karekare areas, which extended into the territory claimed by Borno. He was a Sokoto Fulani *alim* who declared Holy war against Borno Karekare and Katagum.¹⁴ In essence, Rabi was a serious threat to the Sokoto Caliphate, as his intention to attack Kano manifested boldly. He terrorised the Western Borno peasantry who fled to Katagum in large numbers. By 1896, even the recalcitrant Badde had submitted to his rule. He was only welcomed by Shuwa Arabs, some of whom attained positions of importance at his court and was defied only by Jibrila.¹⁵ In line with the above, Hadeja, Jama'are and Misau had all submitted to Rabi. Thus, the Western marches of Borno had submitted; Rabi

¹¹ Abdulhamid Abubakar, 'A New Etymology of the word Kanuri' in *Annals of Borno vol viii/ix 1991/92*, 1993. p 1.

¹² Victor. N. Low, *Three Nigerian Emirates*, pp 66-69.

¹³ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads, A Study of the Wada'abe Pastoral fulani of Western Borno province Northern Region, Nigeria*, Muster-Hamburg: International African Institute 1959 p 33.

¹⁴ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, p 33.

¹⁵ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, p 79.

was planning to attack Kano but was obstructed by Shehu Sanda Kyarimi, who was finally defeated and killed by Rabi.

While Kanuri lost their political power to Rabi, the Fulani, on the other hand, suffered a serious economic setback since they were not far from his ravages. It was said that 'Rabi takes a hundred cattle to make one pot of soup.'¹⁶ This exaggeration was made just to describe the extent of pains suffered by the Fulani, who were the greatest owners of cattle in terms of raids and taxation during the rule of Rabi. In the period between 1887 and 1893, the Rinderpest epidemic reached Borno, and by the time of Rabi's appearance, some of the Wada'abe groups had experienced heavy cattle losses. In particular, the Wada'abe retired westward, where many herd-owners were forced to farm for a few years before being able to resume pastoral life with stocks given to them by less fortunate kinsmen and friends. In Wada'abe traditions, Rabi rapacity (high demand for cattle for tax) is often quoted as the cause of their misfortunes, and only careful questioning makes it possible to separate the two events.¹⁷ These two events were naturally different but were seen by the Fulani as problems associated with the appearance of Rabi. As the Fulani moved westwards, they joined Malam Jibrila in Burmi. Perhaps, when Rabi stopped his brutal raids and settled in Dikwa, most of the Wada'abe returned to their pasture in the 'Great Forest'. Some of them hastened to Dikwa and paid allegiance. Thus, when the lines of Shehu were reinstated by the British, the Wada'abe whose political relationship with Borno had never been more than tentative were tainted not only by their ties with the Fulani Empire, but by their alliance with Jibrilu and their hasty submission to Rabi. The practical definition of their position was not, however, to come for another decade.¹⁸ Thus, the logical conclusion is that the relationship between the two groups during the rule of Rabi and the appearance of the British or the Europeans in general was neither good nor bad.

The Relations between the Kanuri and the Fulani During the Colonial Period

In 1900, an expedition led by General Gentil as part of the French *Le Rendezvous du Chad* defeated Rabi at Kusuri and killed him at the junction of the Shari and Logone rivers. His son Fadl-allah escaped with large followers to Gujba, where he was captured and killed by the French in 1901.¹⁹ The French installed Shehu Umar Sanda as Shehu at Dikwa but later deposed him in favour of Abubakar Garbai. Meanwhile, all the Eastern Emirates of the Fulani Empire, except Hadejia, had submitted to the British after the fall of Kano in 1903, and in 1904, Lord Lugard himself installed Abubakar Garbai as Shehu in Kukawa. Three years later, a new capital was built near the site of the British Fort at Maiduguri.²⁰ Thus, this signified that Borno was fully under British control as a colony in addition to being a protectorate since the time of the Scramble and Partition.

The Colonial period was generally very crucial in studying the relationship between the Kanuri and the Fulani folks. For instance, prior to the Rabi era, the successive Shehus tended to appoint either their relatives or slaves in charge of local administration both in the Kanuri-speaking kingdoms and, in the alien, tribal sectors of the empire. This policy was put to a stop by the British in their interest of smooth administrative operations and security assurance, somehow encouraged

¹⁶ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, p 79.

¹⁷ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, P 79.

¹⁸ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, P 79.

¹⁹ Sa'ad Abubakar, 'Borno in the 19th Century', in Obaro Ikemi, ed, *Groundwork of Nigerian History*, Ibadan, Heinemann Educational Books Plc, 1983, p 344.

²⁰ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, P 85.

the policy. However, in the interest of equality, freedom and liberty, they frequently overrode the nepotistic native administration. Thus, in 1914, there occurred the first change of Residents (Officers), since the province had been set up. The Shehu was now encouraged to remodel his administration so that the customary leaders of each tribal group or village area were given greater responsibility. The work of District Officers lay more and more in finding and supporting these men.²¹ Though the British, through the D.O.s, encouraged this policy of integration of Fulani into the political affairs of Borno, to be fair to the entire political philosophy of Borno, it was the Fulani by their nature of disassociating themselves or distancing themselves from the political affairs of the State right from the beginning. We cited somewhere in this work how their nomadic, trans-human and non-inclusive characters affected them, and instances of Shuwa Arabs, Madara, Wadai and Bulala were integrated into the Kanuri political system. Borno was, and still up to this day is fair to the minority groups of the state. This assertion could be accepted when we critically look at the political arrangements and office-sharing formulas of the present-day Borno. Since independence, the offices of the Governor, Deputy Governor, Senators, Ministers, Ambassadors, down to civil service; offices such as Permanent Secretaries, Directors and all other principal offices in the civil service, have been evenly shared among the various ethnic groups based on their numerical strength. Thus, the present-day Borno is occupied by about 40 different ethnic groups; 15% of its population are Christian and traditional religion followers,²² and have never complained of marginalisation. Therefore, it was not the British that introduce the policy of carrying everyone along to Borno. However, coincidentally, the first decade of the 20th century, during which colonial rule started in Borno, was the period when the Fulani were ready to stay permanently and showed interest in political offices such as village and district headships. It was also a period of relative peace in Borno in which they could settle down without any fear of molestation or harassment.

Another problem associated with the Fulani was that, with sincere apologies to the entire Fulbe folks, they often tended to pursue political power using approaches like threats, trouble or uprisings. By 1900, the Rabi era had gone, and all tensions between Kanuri and Fulani were over, and relative peace and calmness gradually returned as a result of negotiations that had been undertaken between Sokoto and Borno.²³ However, some irregularities were identified by Derrick:

But the main check to the developments planned in 1915 arose through the alleged implication of the West Borno Fulani in Mahadist intrigues. In 1923, a Malam Seyid of Dumbulwa was arrested for preaching Mahadism, and evidence suggested that he had encouraged Fulani Village Heads to accuse District Heads of embezzling tax money. His actions were interpreted by a section of the provincial administration as a deliberate attempt to set up a Fulani kingdom in Western Borno. Although it was pointed out by others that those Fulani Chiefs who could be assumed to have a stake in Borno government-the Village Heads-had had little to do with Seyid, whose Wada'abe following had been drawn from those bush leaders who were ambitious for office. This incident, according to Stenning, again changed the official attitude towards the Wada'abe. West Borno was once more regarded as an alien and recalcitrant enclave, and it was pointed out that this area, as big as a Division, had only one representative of the Central Native Administration. As a remedy, five Kanuris of the Royal family were encouraged to form Village areas there. Kaiuri (Kayeri) District was divided into two. Waziri Momadu was made District Head of the Eastern half, now called after its headquarters, Damaturu District. The Western half was

²¹ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, p 85.

²² Robert J Mundt et al, *Politic in Nigeria, White Plains*, New York: Longman, ISBN9780-321085610, 2001, p 19.

²³ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, p 85.

put under a Kanuri District Head and was called Fune District after its Headquarters on the Potiskum-Maiduguri road where deep drilling experiments were going on (Sic).²⁴

The actions of the Malam Seyid, therefore, were not taken lightly by both colonial and Borno authorities. Political power could be sought in different ways; the simplest and easiest way is total submission and loyalty to the constituted authority. It could be recalled that through submission and absolute loyalty exhibited by many people of slave origin, they have attained political leadership in Borno. Thus, radical approaches of Fulani to political power have greatly contributed to their failures on many occasions in the history of Borno.

The Creation of Fulani Village Heads in Damaturu District

The creation of Fulani village heads, through which the pastoral Fulani of West Borno are used for the collection of taxes and to give political recognition, started in 1919 in Kalalawa. A case study of Damaturu is chosen because it was termed the 'Great Forest of Borno' that attracted nomads from different directions; thus, by the 19th Century, the Damaturu region was the great centre of Fulani influence in Borno. By the late 1940s, there were 21 (twenty-one) village units in Damaturu district, twelve (12) of which were under the headships of Fulani Chiefs. The names of the villages and dates of creation are presented in the table below:

Table One - The Names of the Villages, Clan Groups and Dates of Creation.

S.no	Name of village unit	Date of formation	Clan of Fulani rule the village
1	Barkami	1924	Uda
2	Biriri	19 th Century.	Horewalde
3	Jabrari/Sungul Jabrari	1947	Horewalde
4	Damburam/Sungul Bello	1924	Kutumci
5	Kabaru	1924	Maamaaji
6	Kuillano/Koriyel	1918	Hontore
7	Lantewa	1951	Bibbe Waila
8	Monguno	1918	Uda
9	Muri/Mafa	1928	Mare
10	Ngabaruwa	1919	Mare
11	Koka/Ngarbiwa	1924	Bangaji
12	Kalalawa	1919	Bangaji
13	Bulturi/Sungul Bulturi	1850	Kanuri/Non-Fulani
14	Dabuwa/Bulabulin	1905	Kanuri/Non-Fulani
15	Damaturu	Pre-Jihad	Kanuri/Non-Fulani
16	Gabai	1860	Kanuri/Non-Fulani
17	Gambir	1924	Kanuri/Non-Fulani
18	Mandadawa	1924	Kanuri/Non-Fulani
19	Murfa/Lawan Kalam	1924	Kanuri/Non-Fulani
20	Shekau	1840	Kanuri/Non-Fulani
21	Zokoto/Jimbam	19 th Century.	Kanuri/Non-Fulani

Source: Derrick, *Savannah Nomads*, p. 94.

²⁴ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, p 85.

It is pertinent to note that Damaturu District in the early 19th Century comprises the present Damaturu and Tarmuwa Local Government Areas, Bursari exclusive. Six of the 12 Fulani Chiefs were Wada'abe, and the other six, headed by Kanuri Chiefs, six (Bulturi, Dabagu, Damaturu, Gabai, Shekau and Zogodo) were non-Fulani settlements of long standing in which Fulani pastoral interest was minimal. Mandadawa was a recent settlement of non-Fulani, where pastoral Fulani were of little importance. Two settlements were founded by Fulani but passed into Kanuris hands as their importance as grazing areas declined; they are Murfa, founded by Lawan Kalam, a Bangaji, and Gambir, founded by *Gareeji*, a *Pullo Waila* (*Awalankoen*).

Out of the twelve (12) Fulani Chiefs, four (Jabrari, Damburam, Kabarun and Muli/Muri) were formerly of some importance pastorally but had declined. Two areas were formerly Fulani headships but have been absorbed into others. They were Dusuwa (1918) Horewalde/Yaayagaajooru absorbed into Kalalawa in 1924, and Damya (1924) Horewalde/Dagaaja absorbed by Damaturu in 1932. The remainder (Barkami, Kalalawa, Kuillano/or Koriyel, Monguno or Babbangida Ngabarawa/or Muli/Muri Mafa and Koka) were Fulani headships created in recognition of the predominantly pastoral interests of the areas. Thus, in Damaturu district, the Fulani headships for the most part covered areas endowed for wet-and early dry-season grazing.²⁵ It is difficult to determine the population of Fulani in Damaturu district in those days, but it may not be wrong to say Fulani folks constituted a larger percentage than the Kanuri, considering how village headships were distributed between them. For instance, of the twenty-one (21) village heads in the 20th Century, twelve (12) were headed by Fulani while nine (9) by the Kanuri. Even among the ones headed by Kanuri, little percentage of Fulani pastoral groups were identified. Thus, of the nine (9) Kanuri villages, two (2), Murfa and Gambir, were founded by Fulani but later passed to Kanuri because their grazing activities had declined. Thus, mass migrations of Fulani consequently led to the appointment of Kanuri village heads to the areas.²⁶ Nevertheless, the relationship between the groups in question from the period when village headships of Fulani were created became peaceful and cordial. Thus, from thenceforth, the Fulani folks became part and parcel of the Borno political system.

Conclusion

The research is on the political and administrative relationship between Kanuri and Fulani people of Damaturu Local Government Area of Yobe State. The research is specific to Damaturu and Kanuri and Fulani in particular because Damaturu was called 'Great Forest of Borno' in the 19th Century due to its pasture resources that attracted Fulani nomads from different directions. This made the area a great centre of Fulani influence in the 19th century. Moreover, the groups in question are the two major groups of the study area that have been together for many centuries in the area. The study covers the political situation of Borno at the eve of the Fulani rebellion of 1808, which in the long run resulted in general dissatisfaction of both groups. It studied the position of Damaturu in the 19th-century history of Borno and discovered the influence of the Fulani in the area. This work therefore examined the competition over political offices and the struggle for influence and dominance of identity between the Kanuri and Fulani in Nigeria.

The work discovered that the integration and cooperation of the Fulani into the mainstream of Kanuri Political culture in the first quarter of the 20th Century has been the centrepiece of peaceful

²⁵ Interview with Alhaji Mai Sanda Lawan, (Age: 62, Community leader/Waziri of Damaturu Emirate Council, Damaturu Emirate, 19th December 2023).

²⁶ Derrick J. Stenning, *Savannah Nomads*, p 95.

co-existence between the two groups. The Fulani are often seen as alien settlers in many parts of Nigerian societies. This is largely due to their nomadic and pastoral way of life; to the Kanuri, the Fulani are neither alien nor settlers, but are true sons of the soil. Significantly, many groups with similar history and characteristic of Fulani are often seen as alien or settlers in different regions of Nigeria. This has exposed them to various forms of discrimination. This perhaps led to crises and conflicts. More research is needed on Fulanis' relations with other groups outside this study area to ascertain whether they are viewed as aliens or natives. One important question that readily comes to mind is how long a group of people would live in an area before attaining the status of being indigenes. The work further revealed that competition over political power is the root cause of war between them in the early 19th Century.

This research, therefore, recommends that stakeholders and governments in general should embrace the culture of integration and incorporation of minority groups into the mainstream political and socio-economic life of their States. People and governments at different levels should adopt a friendly and hospitable attitude toward all peace-loving settlers, who, by virtue of their long stay and good character, should be issued a certificate of indigene to enjoy equal opportunities with the natives. These observations are stimulated by widespread conflicts occurring in Nigeria based on the so-called indigene and settler syndrome.

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